First-Time Host Thanksgiving Planner

Plan the menu, shop once and get dinner on the table on time

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13 PAGES

GM's Digital Creations

How to Use This Planner

You do not need to be a great cook to host a great Thanksgiving. You need a plan. Work through these pages in order and the big day takes care of itself.

Your plan, step by step

1. 3 weeks out: fill in the Guest List and the Menu Planner. Ask guests what they will bring.
2. 2 weeks out: use the Turkey Guide to pick a size and decide when it must go in the fridge to thaw.
3. 1 week out: write your Grocery List by store section and shop once for everything that keeps.
4. 2 days out: fill in the Reverse Cooking Timeline. Start from dinner time and work backward.
5. The day before: work through the Day-Before checklist so the morning is calm.
6. After dinner: send leftovers home with the Leftovers page and write thank-yous.

What's inside

- 3-Week Countdown Checklist
- Guest List and Who Brings What
- Menu Planner
- Turkey Size and Thaw Guide
- Reverse Cooking Timeline (worked example)
- Reverse Cooking Timeline (blank)
- Grocery List by Store Section
- Day-Before and Morning-Of Checklist
- Serving Dish and Table Plan
- Leftovers and Thank-You List
- Notes for Next Year

Printing tips

- Print at Actual Size or 100% on US Letter, or Fit to Page on A4.
- Mostly white pages with a warm accent color, so they are easy on ink.
- Print the blank timeline twice: one for a practice run and one for the fridge door.

3-Week Countdown

Check things off as you go. Small steps each week beat one wild day of shopping.

3 weeks before

- [ ] Set the dinner time and send invites
- [ ] Count guests and note any food allergies
- [ ] Plan the menu and decide what guests bring
- [ ] Order a fresh turkey, or buy a frozen one now
- [ ] Check you have a roasting pan, meat thermometer and carving knife

2 weeks before

- [ ] Count plates, glasses, cutlery and chairs
- [ ] Borrow or buy anything missing
- [ ] Plan where coats, drinks and kids will go
- [ ] Make and freeze rolls or pie dough if you like

1 week before

- [ ] Write the grocery list and shop for pantry items and drinks
- [ ] Clean out the fridge to make room for the turkey
- [ ] Pick the serving dishes for every recipe
- [ ] Move a frozen turkey to the fridge on its thaw day (see Turkey Guide)

2 days before

- [ ] Shop for fresh produce and dairy
- [ ] Fill in the Reverse Cooking Timeline
- [ ] Confirm what each guest is bringing

Guest List and Who Brings What

Write every guest, any food needs, and what they will bring. Text this page to your group chat.

Guest	Food needs or allergies	Bringing	Confirmed

Menu Planner

One row per dish. Note who makes it and where it cooks so two dishes never need the oven at the same time.

Course	Dish	Who makes it	Cooks in	Temp and time
Main	Roast turkey	Host	Oven	325°F, see timeline
Side				
Side				
Side				
Bread				
Gravy				
Salad				
Dessert				
Dessert				
Drinks				

Turkey Size and Thaw Guide

Based on USDA guidance for a whole turkey roasted unstuffed at 325°F. Times are a guide; a meat thermometer is the real test.

Turkey weight	Feeds about	Thaw in fridge	Roast time (unstuffed)
8 to 12 lb	6 to 10	1 to 3 days	2 3/4 to 3 hours
12 to 14 lb	10 to 12	3 to 4 days	3 to 3 3/4 hours
14 to 18 lb	12 to 15	4 days	3 3/4 to 4 1/4 hours
18 to 20 lb	15 to 17	4 to 5 days	4 1/4 to 4 1/2 hours
20 to 24 lb	17 to 20	5 to 6 days	4 1/2 to 5 hours

Good to know

- Plan about 1 1/4 lb of turkey per person to have some leftovers.
- Thaw in the fridge: allow about 1 day for every 4 to 5 lb. A 16 lb bird needs about 4 days.
- Done means 165°F in the thickest part of the thigh and the breast. Do not go by color.
- Rest the turkey for 20 to 30 minutes before carving so the juices settle.
- Stuffed turkeys take longer. Many first-time hosts bake the stuffing in a separate dish instead.

My turkey

Weight	Thaw starts (day and date)	Into the oven at	Out by

Reverse Cooking Timeline: Example

Dinner at 4:00 PM with a 14 lb turkey. Start at the bottom with your dinner time and work upward.

Time	Task	Done
10:30 AM	Take the turkey out of the fridge. Remove the neck and giblets, pat dry, season.	
11:00 AM	Preheat the oven to 325°F. Set a rack in the lower third.	
11:30 AM	Turkey into the oven (14 lb, unstuffed, about 3 1/2 to 3 3/4 hours).	
12:00 PM	Set the table and put out serving dishes with sticky-note labels.	
1:00 PM	Chill drinks. Take pies out to come to room temperature.	
2:00 PM	Peel and start boiling the potatoes.	
2:30 PM	Start checking the turkey: thickest part of the thigh and breast should read 165°F.	
3:15 PM	Turkey out, tent loosely with foil to rest. Raise the oven to 350°F.	
3:20 PM	Casserole and stuffing into the oven (about 30 minutes). Make gravy from the drippings.	
3:25 PM	Mash the potatoes and keep them covered on low heat.	
3:45 PM	Carve the turkey. Rolls into the oven for 10 minutes.	
3:55 PM	Everything to the table. Light candles, pour drinks.	
4:00 PM	Dinner is served. Sit down and enjoy it.	

Why it works: the turkey comes out 45 minutes before dinner (30 to rest, 15 to carve). That frees the oven for the sides while it rests.

Reverse Cooking Timeline: My Day

Write your dinner time on the last line first. Then fill each line above it by counting backward.

Time	Task	Done

Grocery List by Store Section

Shop in the order of the store and you will not double back for that one forgotten onion.

Produce

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Meat and turkey

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Dairy and eggs

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Bakery

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Pantry and spices

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Frozen

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Drinks

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Paper goods and other

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Day-Before and Morning-Of

Most of the work can happen the day before. Future you will be grateful.

The day before

- [ ] Bake pies and make cranberry sauce
- [ ] Chop onions, celery and herbs; store in bags
- [ ] Assemble the casserole and refrigerate it
- [ ] Make sure the turkey is fully thawed
- [ ] Set out serving dishes with labels
- [ ] Run and empty the dishwasher
- [ ] Clear counter space and take out the trash
- [ ] Charge your phone and set timer reminders

The morning of

- [ ] Turkey out of the fridge 1 hour before roasting
- [ ] Tidy the bathroom guests will use
- [ ] Make ice or buy a bag
- [ ] Set the table
- [ ] Put out a snack so nobody hovers in the kitchen
- [ ] Pull up your timeline and start your first timer

Kitchen helpers

Job	Helper
Drinks and ice	
Greeting guests and coats	
Carving	
Clearing plates	
Dishes	

Serving Dish and Table Plan

Match every dish to a bowl and a spoon now, so nothing is scrambled for at the last minute.

Dish	Serving dish	Utensil	Warm or cold	Labeled

Seating

Leftovers and Thank-You List

Send food home in labeled containers and say thanks while the day is still fresh.

Leftovers

Who	What they took	Container to return?

Thank-you notes

Who	Thank them for	Sent

Notes for Next Year

Write it down while you remember. Next year you will host like a pro.

What worked well

What to change

Dishes that were a hit

Buy more of / buy less of

You just made my day!

Thank you for choosing a small, one-person shop over the big guys.

Quick favor? If this made your party or planning even a little easier, a 30-second review helps the next family find it. I read every single one.

How: Etsy app → You → Purchases → Leave a review

Something not right? Message me first and I'll fix it fast.

With thanks,

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